# Free Printable: Our Toddler Bedtime Routine Chart (Fridge-Tested)

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The thing that finally made bedtime work in our house wasn't a new routine. It was putting the routine on the fridge where our daughter could see it.

We had the steps down — tidy up, bath, teeth, PJs, story, hugs, lights out — but every night turned into a negotiation about what came next. "Can I play a bit more?" "Do I have to brush teeth tonight?" She wasn't being difficult, exactly. She just couldn't hold the whole sequence in her head, so every transition felt like a surprise. And surprises at 8pm are never received well.

So I made a chart. Seven steps, big checkboxes, little pictures. I printed it, stuck it on the fridge with a magnet shaped like a pizza slice, and handed her a crayon. The first night she marched through the whole routine pointing at each step and announcing it like a tiny project manager. "TIDY UP. DONE." It took half the usual time. I almost cried.

Here's what I learned from watching her use it for the last month:

The checking-off is the whole point. It's not about the pictures or even the order — it's that she can see progress. Toddlers live entirely in the present moment, and "we're almost done" means nothing to them. Five checked boxes means everything. On rough nights I point at the chart instead of arguing, which means I'm not the bad guy anymore. The chart is the bad guy. The chart doesn't get tired or raise its voice.

Keep the steps in the same order every night. I was tempted to shuffle things around, but the predictability is the feature. She now starts tidying up on her own when she sees me heading for the bathroom to run the bath. That's not obedience, that's just a kid who knows what happens next and feels good about it.

Let her check the boxes herself, even if the checkmarks are enormous scribbles over the whole row. Ownership matters more than neatness. We tried me checking them off for a while and the magic faded within days. The crayon is load-bearing.

If a step gets skipped, the empty checkbox does the nagging for you. “Looks like teeth didn’t get checked off” lands completely differently than “go brush your teeth right now.” I don’t fully understand why, but I’ll take it.

**Download the free printable bedtime routine chart (PDF)** — it’s one page, prints fine in color or black and white, and there’s a row of stars at the bottom for the nights when everything goes right. Stick it on your fridge and hand over the crayon. Let me know how it goes.